more than ever before with the BJP's political ideas and expressed this through their vote in successive elections from 2014 onwards. It started from a fundamental personal belief that it was vital at this point in India's national journey to understand the levers of its political growth dispassionately. One needed to step away from the sound and fury of toxic television studios, venomous social-media trolls, political slugfests and daily hand-wringing over what was happening to India (by those who opposed the BJP) or celebrations over the country's new turn (by those who supported it), and work instead with empirical evidence, facts and a fresh cross-disciplinary understanding beyond the multiple cultural divides that the party embodies.

Why did the BJP start winning on this scale? Was it only because of a cultural shift in India? Or was its edifice of expansion built on creating a much wider, deeper superstructure of new constituencies of voters who aligned with it for reasons beyond the cultural divide? How did the BJP's growth patterns differ across India's regions, in new catchment areas where it had never held sway before or in areas where it failed to make inroads? In other words, what really was happening in India, how did the BJP systematically become the country's largest political party and its fulcrum of power? These are the fundamental questions I seek to answer. There are, of course, a variety of ways to address such questions. My training as a student of politics and as a journalist covering Indian politics over twenty years impels me to favour a fact-based narrative. I draw on written sources, field visits, interviews and conversations as well as archival and documentary evidence.

The germ of this project was born out of my daily work as a political analyst and editor working with micro-level election data. Since 2017, when the data scientist Rishabh Srivastava and I started putting together micro-constituency and booth-level voting data sets across elections, using layers of subjective queries and artificial intelligence (AI) filters to study them, we started seeing confounding patterns that challenged the conventional understanding of Indian politics that I had long been used to. These counter-intuitive patterns also started showing up more and more in ground-level conversations with key actors when I travelled across several states,